For whenever he spoke to the king, he blushed deeply'. No doubt Acquaviva would have blushed that first evening, too, in the company of the 'Great Mogul', and in the expectation of all that he wished so ardently to accomplish.

Akbar invited the Jesuits to join in the discussions at the ibadat khana in the cool evenings, where the different religious groups were placed separately around the hall and Akbar walked eagerly from one group to the next, asking questions. One of the first questions discussed was the relative merits of the Bible versus the Koran. With their ecstatic mission to convert the Mughal Padshah burning in their hearts, the Jesuits unapologetically attacked the Koran, 'stuffed with countless fables full of futility and extreme frivolity' while upholding the 'accuracy and authority of the Holy Scriptures'. So impassioned and virulent was Acquaviva's attack that, after a while, the Muslim theologians fell into a complete, and ominous, silence. At the end of the evening Akbar called aside Monserrate and Henriques and, upset at the intemperance of the younger theologian's attack, asked the two Jesuits to control the tenor of their colleague's rhetoric.

The discussions continued for several weeks and while Akbar enjoyed many of the teachings of the Bible, he was most discomfited by the ideas, well known to Muslims, of the Holy Trinity, the Virgin birth, and the fact that Jesus had allowed himself the indignity of death on the cross. Akbar was extremely disappointed by his own Muslim theologians because they did not counter the Jesuits with unified arguments, and themselves offered varied and contradictory positions. At one point, seemingly tired and disheartened by these recriminatory discussions, Akbar suggested that one theologian from each party undergo a trial by fire, protected by the righteousness of their holy book, to test which scripture contained the Supreme Truth. Unsurprisingly, no one rushed to accept this proposal and the night ended with loud, conciliatory shouts of 'Peace be to the King!'

Akbar continued to be unfailingly gracious and kind to his Jesuit guests. He told them that 'it was his desire that Christians should live freely in his empire, and build their churches, as he had heard was the case in Turkey…. He made this declaration with plain signs of great love and kindliness.' To the great astonishment of the Jesuits, Akbar once put on Portuguese costume, a scarlet cloak with gold fastenings, and a Portuguese hat. He made the three young princes wear similar clothes and spent an evening listening to madrigals with them. He had the Jesuits shifted from their noisy